

Sentinels of the Dawn

Poor Clares of Perpetual Adoration
Our Lady of the Angels Monastery
Troyes, France

Christmas 2017 — Issue 20

And the Word was made flesh and dwelt among us...

By becoming man, God has in a certain way united Himself with every human person. He has revealed to us the truth about who He is – He is Love. He has revealed to us also that every human being has dignity, including the unborn child, the poor, the outcast, the suffering, the aged and the dying. By becoming man, God came to earth to deliver us from sin and death. He came to make all things new; to bring about the new creation. He took on our human nature so that we might become partakers of His divine nature, that we become sharers in the life of the Blessed Trinity. The Fathers and Doctors of the Church speak of the Christmas mystery as "a wonderful exchange" between God and man: He takes what is ours so that He may give us what is His. In sending His Son, God has opened for us a share in His divine life, the power, Saint John says, to become children of God! (John 3:12)



Saint Francis of Assisi was so moved by the mystery of Christmas that he began the custom of the Christmas crèche with live figures. His love for poverty led him to this special appreciation for the wonder of that first Christmas. One of his great followers, Saint Bonaventure, wrote the following: "The King of kings and Lord of lords has become the slave and humble servant of men… God, supremely glorious, dwelling in the heights of majesty, has dwelt in a lonely manger." At Christmas we do not honor or worship a powerful emperor, but rather an infant wrapped in swaddling clothes and lying in a manger, the One announced by the angel as the Savior, who is Christ and Lord. We worship Him who gives meaning to our lives, who offers us eternal life and salvation. In becoming man, He has brought eternity to us and so we live as a people of hope. This virtue of hope is truly a virtue of Christmas. In the midst of so much anxiety and despair in our world, may we be witnesses of Christian hope!

May Jesus, born in the silence on the holiest of all nights in Bethlehem, bless you and your loved ones with His love and peace!

On June 17th, the Solemnity of Corpus Christi, we had the great joy of announcing the news that our Monastery had been named the Eucharistic Sanctuary of the Diocese of Troyes. The decree, written and signed by our Bishop, the Most Reverend Marc Stenger, was read at the end of Mass in our Chapel on this special day when the Church honors the Body and Blood of Our Lord Jesus Christ really present in the Most Blessed Sacrament. Since our particular charism is Eucharistic Adoration, it is our great desire that others will discover this "hidden treasure" and will join us in adoring our Lord, solemnly exposed in our Chapel. In 2018 we will begin to propose ways that all can participate in the mission that our Bishop has entrusted to us.

During this holy season of Christmas, we invite you to spend time in prayer before Jesus in the Most Blessed Sacrament, even if you only have five minutes. He is waiting to lavish graces and blessings upon you!



Nowhere on earth are we more welcomed or loved than by Jesus in the Eucharist. When you look at the crucifix, you understand how much Jesus loved you. When you look at the Sacred Host you understand how much Jesus loves you now.

Jesus has made Himself the Bread of Life to give us life. Night and day, He is there. If you really want to grow in love, come back to the Eucharist, come back to that Adoration. - *St. Teresa of Calcutta*

Opening wide the doors of our hearts

The past few months have been filled with much joy in receiving a number of visitors to our Monastery. In October we welcomed with open arms



Sister Martino Marie and Sister Antonin Marie

and hearts two new young Sisters to our Community, Sister Antonin Marie and Sister Martino Marie, who come to us from our Monastery in Visakhapatnam, India. They were accompanied in their travel to France by their Abbess, Mother Mary Philippa. It was a delight to have Mother with us, even though the time passed too quickly. During her visit she prayed at the tombs of our founders, Father Bonaventure Heurlaut and Mother Marie of Sainte Claire Bouillevaux. It was a particularly joyful reunion for our Sister Mary Rosalia and Sister Mary Germaine who had not seen Mother Mary Philippa since their days in the Novitiate in our Quilon Monastery (India). We are grateful to Mother Mary Philippa and our Sister in Visakhapatnam for their generosity in sending Sister Mary Raphaël in 2013 and now two more Sisters to our cradle Monastery to help us in our mission.



Sister Mary Rosalia and Sister Mary Germaine rejoice in visiting with Mother Mary Philippa after so many years.

When our two new arrivals are not busy learning French and continuing their formation studies, they work as "new recruits" in the sewing room. So far they have kept their beautiful smiles!



L to R: Mother M. Seraphina, Mother Marie Emmanuel and Sister Marie Rose

A week after Mother Mary Philippa's departure, we had the privilege of welcoming Mother M. Seraphina, President of the Polish Federation of our Monasteries. At the end of her six-year term, Mother M. Seraphina wished to visit our Communities in Troyes and Castelnaudary. Sister Marie Rose from our Monastery in Zabkowice, Poland, accompanied Mother and served as our translator. She had spent a year with us in 2015 so, needless to say, we were happy to see her once again and to have the opportunity to finally meet Mother M. Seraphina, who was re-elected President at the end of November.



L to R : Fr. Leonardo and Fr. Antonie posing with their their "Brother in Christ" Saint Anthony!

To complete the numerous visits from our Franciscan family, Father Leonardo Ariel Gonzalez, the Delegate of the Minister General of the Capuchins to the Poor Clares visited our Monastery in early November. He was accompanied by Father Antonie Haddad, who acted as translator. During their time with us, Father Leonardo gave us a beautiful conference on the latest apostolic letter of our Holy Father, for cloistered religious, "Seeking the Face of God". He emphasized the importance of our Community's mission as the protomonastery of our Institute. He also spoke of the great need for perpetual adoration in a world which is thirsting for God. Our time of sharing was very fruitful and we were touched by his fraternal support, his desire to offer his assistance, as well as for his counsel. We are grateful for this visit which strengthened our fratenal bonds with our Capuchins Brothers who serve the spiritual needs of our Monasteries throughout the world.



One afternoon in September, our Sister went to answer the door and upon opening it, discovered not ***one*** Poor Clare Sister from Vermand, but the entire Community! They were returning to their Monastery after a retreat and they decided to stop by and say "hello"! We spent the afternoon together, sharing and rejoicing in God's goodness!



Making music for the Lord

The following is a short interview with our Sister Mary Antoinette.

Sister Mary Antoinette, would you be able to tell us briefly about your latest CD, entitled Saint Thaïs?

Sister Mary Antoinette: The CD contains an assortment of religious and meditative pieces for violin, some with organ accompaniment. There are several transcriptions of Gregorian chants as well as two original compositions. At
the end is a transcription of Bach's Toccata and Fugue in D Minor for solo violin, recorded in 2013 at the Cathedral in Troyes with Michael Matthes.

Saint Thaïs, who is she and why did you choose to name the CD in her honor?

SMA: It was difficult to find a title for the CD because of the mixture of composers and styles. A Sister suggested choosing the title from one of the pieces. Finally we decided on the "Meditation from Thaïs" , the opera by the French composer Jules Massenet based on a « romanticized » version of her life. Who is she ? Saint Thaïs was, in fact, a courtesan in 4th-century Alexandria, Egypt who was converted by a holy monk. A few years ago I happened to find her name and Feast Day (October 8th) in a book on Lives of the Saints in the Monastery library. It was a great revelation ! Every young violinist studies this piece after reaching a certain level of competence, as it is an important part of the violinist's repertoire. But few, if any, know that Thaïs was a real saint, not just the main character of an opera. So we decided to name the CD after her.

Would you speak to us about the image that you chose for the cover of your CD?

SMA: The image reproduced on the cover of the CD is a painting by José de Ribera (+1652) which is sometimes referred to as a painting of Saint Mary Magdalene. There is a great similarity between the two Saints, who turned away from lives of sin toward prayer and penitence.

Of all the partitions that you have recorded on this latest CD, which one is your favorite and why?

SMA: The Ave Maria of Bach-Gounod, because it was a favorite of my parents and they told me that it was sung at their wedding.

If you are interested in purchasing a copy of Sister Mary Antoinette's CD, please visit our website:



www.claissesdetroyes.com

A time set apart for God



For our annual Community retreat in September, Father Bernard Gundabert, OP from the Dominicain Convent of the Annunciation in Paris graciously accepted our invitation to be the retreat master. He was recommended to us by one of his brother priests, Father Eric de Clermont Tonnerre, OP who had given us a series of conferences during the Year of Consecrated Life in 2015.

During our days of recollection, Father's conferences focused on the theme of "leaving" which marks every human life and spiritual journey. Abraham, Moses, Our Lady and St Paul were offered as models to guide us in our own spiritual journey. We were grateful for this sacred time set apart to listen to God speak to our hearts through His Word and through the wisdom and experience of this spiritual son of Saint Dominic.

A time to renovate





As the end of 2017 draws to a close, so too does our current renovation project. In early January our Sisters will be able to move into their new bedrooms and begin the task of setting up our new library and the area created for the precious archives of our Order. We wish to express our deep gratitude to all those who supported us with their generous donations and to the Foundation of Monasteries for an important subvention that allowed us to complete this phase of the renovation of our Monastery. Although much work awaits us in other areas of the Monastery, we give thanks for what has already been accomplished these past ten years. A special thank you to our architect, Mr. Jacques Téqui, for his expertise in overseeing these projects.

Ave, Ave, Ave Maria !



In honor of the Centenary of our Lady's apparitions to the three shepherd children of Fatima, a Solemn Mass was celebrated in our Chapel on May 13th. A statue of our Lady of Fatima was carried in procession, enthroned in the sanctuary and blessed by the Most Reverend Yves Patenôtre, retired Archbishop of the diocese of Sens-Auxerre, who presided at the Mass. On the 13th of each month, a consecration prayer to our Lady of Fatima composed by our Holy Father was recited at the end of Mass. In the evening, following Vespers, we recited the Holy Rosary using scripture meditations for each decade.

May we continue to entrust ourselves to our Lady's maternal protection, imploring her to intercede for us, through her Son, and for all her children throughout the world. May peace reign in areas where there is violence, war and persecutions, as well as in the home of families and in the hearts of us all.

MONASTERE DES CLARISSES
26 RUE MITANTIER
10000 TROYES, FRANCE



The Poor Clares of Perpetual Adoration in Troyes, France wish you and your loved ones a Blessed Christmas and many graces and blessings in the New Year 2018!

The Chronicles of Symba

As promised, I am back (by popular demand!) to recount to you some of my latest adventures of life in the cloister with the Poor Clares Sisters of Troyes. This past year has been a busy one with lots of activity... numerous workers have been coming in and out for what the Sisters call a "renovation project". There are two new Sisters in the Community and several others have visited these past few months. I have enjoyed meeting them and receiving lots of attention (and caresses, too!) Everyone compliments me on what a good dog I am ! I try to obey all the rules of my mistress, but sometimes it's hard. By nature, I'm very observant. For instance, one day I noticed that one of the gates in the yard was open and no one saw me. So I snuck out of the cloister and took a stroll around the neighborhood. Unfortunately, my little outing didn't last too long, as one of the Sisters came searching for me, my leash in hand. Another time, one of the Sisters went to answer the door and after returning with two long cartons in her hands, she set them down temporarily on a table and walked off. Of course, I seized the opportunity to investigate. I jumped up on my hind legs, sniffed at the boxes and couldn't resist the temptation to open them! You can probably guess what followed... When the Sister returned, I thought she would be happy that at least I saved her two of the 24 eggs in the cartons. In the end, I regretted my actions... and so did my stomach ! I guess I still have a few lessons to learn in life...



I wish you a very Merry Christmas and many new adventures in 2018 !